

B0B04B22 - Anglický jazyk B2-2

WEEK 9

Abstract nouns* + of + -ing / to-infinitive

Scanning for Information (Prepositions / Vocabulary / Word Formation Practice)

Reading Comprehension Practice

Abstract nouns* are words for things that are intangible - things you cannot see, touch, smell, taste, or hear with your five senses. They represent ideas, concepts, emotions, qualities, and states of being.

Abstract nouns are common in academic writing, and it is important to understand the grammatical structures that follow these words.

Abstract nouns + of + -ing / to-infinitive

Some abstract nouns that are common in academic writing can be followed by a *to-infinitive* (e.g., *to do*), some by *of + -ing* (e.g., *of doing*), and some by either* a *to-infinitive* or *of + -ing* with a similar meaning.

PRACTICE:

For each of the sentences below (1 - 18) choose the correct option of the words in **bold**.

- (1) This was due to their failure **of competing / to compete** with US companies in Asian markets.
- (2) Children from poor families have a higher risk **of becoming / to become** criminals.
- (3) As more migrants came, there was a tendency **of living / to live** near people from the same country of origin.
- (4) There are undoubtedly negative effects **of surfing / to surf** on the internet.
- (5) Donors now have the possibility **of giving / to give** online.
- (6) The right person for the job must show a capacity **of working / to work** independently.
- (7) This method **of growing / to grow** tomatoes never fails.
- (8) Most students face the problem **of funding / to fund** themselves while they are studying.
- (9) The company reserves the right **of cancelling / to cancel** this agreement in certain circumstances.
- (10) Students need the ability **of constructing / to construct** a logical argument.
- (11) "Failure is simply the opportunity **of beginning / to begin** again, this time more intelligently." Henry Ford
- (12) Internet banking will considerably reduce the cost **of doing / to do** business.
- (13) An enzyme in the saliva of the mouth starts the process **of breaking / to break** down the food.
- (14) They had no means **of letting / to let** him know that the flight was canceled.
- (15) He made no attempt **of being / to be** sociable.
- (16) The police have the power **of entering / to enter** the premises at any time.
- (17) In an effort **of controlling / to control** costs, they have allowed their human resources (HR) staff to restrict employees' choice.
- (18) She remained bitterly opposed to the idea **of moving / to move** abroad.

NOTE: THIS GRAMMATICAL STRUCTURE WILL BE TESTED ON THE B2-2 FINAL SEMESTER TEST.

HOWEVER – IT WILL NOT BE TESTED AS ITS OWN SECTION ON THE B2 EXAM.

THIS STRUCTURE WILL BE HELPFUL IN OTHER SECTIONS SUCH AS THE KEY WORD SENTENCE TRANSFORMATIONS.

+ to-infinitive

EFFORT

ABILITY

ATTEMPT

CAPACITY

FAILURE

POWER

RIGHT

TENDENCY

+ of + -ing

IDEA

COST

EFFECT

POSSIBILITY

PROBLEM

PROCESS

RISK

either to-infinitive or of + -ing*

WAY

MEANS

METHOD

OPPORTUNITY

***NOTE:** With regard to those abstract nouns which can take either the *to-infinitive* or *of + -ing*, please note that the following appear most frequently in academic writing. They are also "collocations" – meaning it simply sounds right / better.

OPPORTUNITY / OPPORTUNITIES (+ *to-infinitive*)

MEANS (+ *of + -ing*)

METHOD(s) (+ *of + -ing*)

WAY(s) (+ *of + -ing*)

PART 1: Preposition Practice

Read the following text and fill in the blank spaces (1 - 25) with the correct preposition where needed. THERE MAY BE SOME SPACES THAT DO NOT REQUIRE ANYTHING.

Gender Bias and the Glass Ceiling

Even though the majority (1) _____ women work outside the home, women in high status jobs are unusual (Mitchell, 2000); in 2006 only about 23% of all CEOs – and only 10 of the Fortune 500 companies – were headed (2) _____ women. Not until 1981 was a woman, Sandra Day O'Connor, appointed to the U.S. Supreme Court; it took another 12 years before a second woman, Ruth Bader Ginsburg, was appointed. Few women serve in the highest ranks of major corporations, and women are substantially outnumbered (3) _____ the senior faculty level of most universities and colleges.

Why are there so few women (4) _____ such positions? The most important reason is gender discrimination: denying a job to someone solely on the basis of whether the person is a man or a woman. Lovoy (2001) points (5) _____ that gender discrimination is pervasive in the workplace. Despite some progress (6) _____ the past two decades, sex discrimination is still common: women are being kept out of high status jobs by the men (7) _____ the top (Barnes, 2005; Reid, Miller & Kerr, 2004).

Research in the United States and Britain also confirms that women are forced to work harder than men (Gorman & Krnec, 2007). Neither differences (8) _____ job characteristics nor family obligations account (9) _____ this difference; the results clearly point (10) _____ stricter job performance standards being applied to women.

Women themselves refer to a glass ceiling: the level (11) _____ which they may rise (12) _____ an organization but beyond which they may not go. The glass ceiling is a major barrier for women (Maume, 2004), and the greatest barrier facing them is at the boundary between lower-tier and upper-tier grades. Men are largely blind (13) _____ the existence of the glass ceiling (Heppner, 2007). Women tend to move to the top of the lower tier and remain there, whereas men are more readily promoted (14) _____ the upper tier even when other factors (e.g. personal attributes, qualifications, job performance) are controlled (Lovoy, 2001).

The glass ceiling is pervasive across workplace settings (Heppner, 2007), including private corporations (Lyness & Thompson, 1997), government agencies (Reid et al., 2004), and nonprofit organizations (Shaiko, 1996). The glass ceiling has also been used to account (15) _____ why African Americans and Asian Americans do not advance as much in their careers as do European American men (Hwang, 2007; Johnson, 2000; Phelps & Constantine, 2001). It also provides a framework for understanding limitations to women's careers (16) _____ many countries around the world (Mugadza, 2005; Zafarulla, 2000).

What can be done to begin (17) _____ eliminating the glass ceiling? Mitchell (2000) suggests that companies must begin to value the competencies women develop, such as being more democratic and interpersonally oriented than men, and to assist men (18) _____ feeling more comfortable with their female colleagues. Mentoring is also an important aspect. Lovoy (2001) adds that companies must be more proactive (19) _____ promoting diversity, provide better and more detailed feedback about performance and where employees stand regarding promotion, and establish ombuds offices (company offices where employees can complain (20) _____ working conditions or their supervisor without retribution) that help women deal with difficulties (21) _____ the job.

In addition to discrimination in hiring and promoting, women are also subject to pay discrimination. According to the Bureau of Labor Statistics (2007a), in only 13 of the hundreds of occupations they track did women earn at least 95% of men in the same occupations. (22) _____ average, women are paid about 81% of what men are paid (23) _____ an annual basis.

Several solutions (24) _____ this problem have been promoted. One of these is pay equity: equalizing pay across occupations that are determined to be equivalent in importance but differ in the gender distribution of the people doing the jobs. Determining which male-dominated occupations should be considered equivalent to which female-dominated occupations for pay purposes is difficult and controversial. In their comprehensive look (25) _____ pay inequity, Dey and Hill (2007) suggested several actions to address the problem: encouraging women to negotiate salary more effectively, rethinking the use of hours worked as the primary measure of productivity, creating more work options for working mothers, and ending gender discrimination in the workplace.

PART 2: Scanning for Information ← *OPTIONAL EXERCISE*

[Page 3]

Look at the following statements made in the text from the previous page.
Did the writer say these statements apply mainly to women **(W)** or to men **(M)**.
Go back and scan the text, if necessary.

- | | |
|---|---------------|
| (1) They are unusual in high status jobs. | <u> W </u> |
| (2) They comprise about a quarter of all CEOs. | <u> </u> |
| (3) Fewer serve in the highest ranks of major corporations. | <u> </u> |
| (4) They face gender discrimination in the workplace. | <u> </u> |
| (5) They have stricter job performance standards applied to them. | <u> </u> |
| (6) They are largely blind to the existence of the glass ceiling. | <u> </u> |
| (7) They are more readily promoted to upper-tier grades. | <u> </u> |
| (8) They are more democratic and interpersonally oriented. | <u> </u> |
| (9) They earn less in the same occupation. | <u> </u> |
| (10) They should negotiate salary more effectively. | <u> </u> |

PART 3: Vocabulary / Word Formation (...words from the text on page 2)

Complete the following sentences (1 - 20) by filling in the blank spaces with **the proper form of the word given for that sentence**. Use ONLY ONE word per blank space: DO NOT add any words [e.g. prepositions].

- | | |
|---------------------|---|
| (1) COMPETENCE | She was mentally _____ and she had the capacity to decide for herself. |
| (2) MEASURE | The exact _____ of this angle is 90 degrees 40 minutes, which can be written as 90° 40'. |
| (3) EQUAL | Women do not yet have true _____ in the company. |
| (4) LIMIT | Our field of vision is _____ by that tall building. |
| (5) COMPREHEND | It will have been one of the most _____ designed and tested lifeboats to have been built anywhere in the world. |
| (6) NEGOTIATE | The terms of employment are _____. |
| (7) PRODUCT | They _____ two reports, neither of which contained any useful suggestions. |
| (8) EQUALITY | An imperial gallon, used in Britain, is _____ to 4546 cubic centimetres. |
| (9) LIMIT | Scientists are attempting to harness the _____ power of the sun. |
| (10) PROMOTION | We need to _____ an open exchange of ideas and information. |
| (11) MEASURE | The service produces clear, _____ benefits to people's health. |
| (12) OBLIGATION | Tenants are _____ to pay their rent on time. |
| (13) OCCUPY | Women have yet to achieve wage or _____ equality in many fields. |
| (14) PRODUCT | The application of new scientific discoveries to industrial _____ methods usually increases efficiency. |
| (15) DISCRIMINATION | She felt she had been _____ against because of her age. |
| (16) CORPORATION | The company is moving its _____ headquarters from New York to Houston. |
| (17) NEGOTIATE | The police _____ with the gunman through an intermediary. |
| (18) QUALIFY | She's extremely well _____ for the job. |
| (19) COMPETENCE | A lawyer should represent a client _____. |
| (20) DISCRIMINATION | A test is useful for _____ those students who have reached a higher level from those at a lower level. |

READING COMPREHENSION

[Page 4]

Read the following passage - then choose the best answer (a, b, c, d or e) for each of the questions (1 - 6).

The biggest house of cards, the longest tongue, and of course, the tallest man: these are among the thousands of records logged in the famous Guinness Book of Records. Created in 1955 after a debate concerning Europe's fastest game bird, what began as a marketing tool sold to pub landlords to promote Guinness, an Irish drink, became the bestselling copyright title of all time (a category that excludes books such as the Bible and the Koran). In time, the book would sell 120 million copies in over 100 countries—quite a leap from its humble beginnings.

In its early years, the book set its sights on satisfying man's innate curiosity about the natural world around him. Its two principal fact finders, twins Norris and Ross McWhirter, scoured the globe to collect **empirical** facts. It was their task to find and document aspects of life that can be sensed or observed, things that can be quantified or measured. But not just any things. They were only interested in **superlatives**: the biggest and the best. It was during this period that some of the hallmark Guinness Records were documented, answering such questions as "What is the brightest star?" and "What is the biggest spider?"

Once aware of the public's thirst for such knowledge, the book's authors began to branch out to cover increasingly obscure, little-known facts. They started documenting human achievements as well. A **forerunner** for reality television, the Guinness Book gave people a chance to become famous for accomplishing eccentric, often pointless tasks.

Records were set in 1955 for consuming 24 raw eggs in

14 minutes and in 1981 for the fastest solving of a Rubik's Cube (which took a mere 38 seconds). In 1979 a man yodeled non-stop for ten and a quarter hours.

In its latest incarnation, the book has found a new home on the internet. No longer restricted to the confines of physical paper, the Guinness World Records website contains seemingly innumerable facts concerning such topics as the most powerful combustion engine, or the world's longest train. What is striking, however, is that such facts are found sharing a page with the record of the heaviest train to be pulled with a beard. While there is no denying that each of these facts has its own, individual **allure**, the latter represents a significant deviation from the education-oriented facts of earlier editions. Perhaps there is useful knowledge to be gleaned regarding the tensile strength of a beard, but this seems to cater to an audience more interested in seeking entertainment than education.

Originating as a simple bar book, the Guinness Book of Records has evolved over decades to provide insight into the full spectrum of modern life. And although one may be more likely now to learn about the widest human mouth than the highest number of casualties in a single battle of the Civil War, the Guinness World Records website offers a telling glimpse into the future of fact-finding and record-recording.

(1) Which of the following statements would best serve as the headline for this passage?

- a) The encyclopedia of the extremes reflects the changing interests of modern society.
- b) A book of simple origins makes it to the top as sales total a staggering 120 million copies.
- c) Facts are often displayed in a boring, uninteresting manner, but not in the Guinness Book of Records.
- d) The Guinness World Records website proves itself a valuable resource for insight into the full spectrum of modern life.
- e) Where other books fall short, the index of superlative sciences never ceases to amaze.

(2) According to the author, the most significant difference between older editions of the Guinness Book of Records and the new Guinness World Records website involves...

- a) ...an end to the use of facts as a means to promote Guinness.
- b) ...an overall increase in the total number of facts presented.
- c) ...a move from fact-finding to the recording of achievements.
- d) ...a shift in focus from educational to entertaining material.
- e) ...a departure from book sales being limited to local pubs and bars.

(3) As used in paragraph 2, which is the best definition for empirical?

- a) natural
- b) derived from experience
- c) recordable
- d) excellent or unmatched
- e) convenient or handy

(4) Based on its use in paragraph 2, which of the following best describes something that is superlative?

- a) Students give presentations about their favorite subjects for a grade. Amy Newhouse receives an 87% for her presentation, while Dustin Lincoln receives a 92%.
- b) Although sharks are significantly bigger and have razor-sharp teeth, dolphins are smarter and can therefore successfully evade attack.
- c) The lake holds a contest to see who can catch the biggest fish. Tommy wins, having caught a 6 lb. 5 oz. smallmouth bass.
- d) A man built an enormous house of cards. It took him 44 days and 218,792 individual playing cards to complete.
- e) Ichiro likes tennis and practices every day. In his last tournament, he placed 3rd of over 350 competitors, winning the bronze trophy.

(5) Using the passage as a guide, it can be inferred that the author most likely believes reality television to be...

- a) ...corrupt.
- b) ...absurd.
- c) ...idiotic.
- d) ...invaluable.
- e) ...shallow.

(6) Which of the following best summarizes the organization of this passage?

- a) introduction, history, conclusion
- b) history, examples, explanations, conclusion
- c) exposition, history, conclusion
- d) introduction, thesis, supporting paragraphs, conclusion
- e) introduction, history, exposition, conclusion